Tesla Shows Off a Roadster That Can Lift Into the Air

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Can a car fly? On Thursday night, Tesla and its CEO, Elon Musk, showed off the new Roadster 2 at an event in McGregor, Texas. The event took place at a rocket testing site run by SpaceX, another company Musk leads.

During the **demonstration**, the car burst into the air with a jerky puff of steam. At one point, it seemed to float several feet above Tesla's electric semi-truck. Tesla's head of vehicle engineering, Lars Moravy, said the "flying" is made possible by four **thrusters**. Tesla said the **thrusters** are powered by **compressed gas** stored in the car. Musk said the same technology will push the car down toward the road so it can take corners very quickly.

Tesla executives said the car could speed up from 0 to 60 miles per hour in one second. Moravy said the final version would "hopefully" reach up to 230 miles per hour. Musk said, "This is not necessarily a safety-optimized car." Wired noted that the car is likely to get attention from government safety **regulators**.

Tesla says it will start making the Roadster 2 in 2028. Fans have waited a long time. The car was first announced in 2017, and Tesla originally promised it would ship in 2020. Wired pointed out that many Tesla products have missed their planned release dates in the past. Tesla did not say how much the new car will cost.

The company says there will be three **versions**: a two-seat road version without **thrusters**, a "race ready" version, and a one-seat "air ready" version.

The **unveiling** comes at a tricky time for electric cars. Wired reports that electric car sales have stalled in the United States but are booming in some other parts of the world.

Word Treasure

unveiling -- The first time something new is shown to the public.

demonstration -- A show of how something works.

thrusters -- Devices that push something by blasting out gas in the opposite direction.

compressed gas -- Gas squeezed into a small space under high pressure so it can release force.

regulators -- Government officials who make and enforce safety rules.

versions -- Different forms of the same product.

Background you need

Tesla is a company best known for making electric cars, which run on batteries instead of gasoline.

The original Roadster was Tesla's first car, and the Roadster 2 was announced as its follow-up sports car.

Thrusters work by pushing gas out quickly in one direction, which pushes the vehicle the other way.

New vehicles sold in the United States must meet government safety rules before people can drive them on public roads.

Break it down

LEAD: Tesla unveiled the Roadster 2 at a SpaceX rocket testing site in McGregor, Texas
KEY EVENT: A demonstration car lifted into the air using four thrusters
+- WHO: Elon Musk and engineering head Lars Moravy
+- WHEN: Thursday night
CLAIMS: 0 to 60 mph in one second; top speed hopefully up to 230 mph
CONCERNS: Musk said it is not necessarily safety-optimized; Wired notes past missed release dates
DETAILS: Production planned for 2028; three versions; price not announced
CONTEXT: Electric car sales have stalled in the US but are booming elsewhere

Why it matters

Bold new vehicle designs show how engineers test new ideas, but they also raise questions about safety rules and whether promises will be kept.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Tesla show off the Roadster 2?

- (A) Austin, Texas
- (B) Detroit, Michigan
- (C) Los Angeles, California
- (D) McGregor, Texas

2. How many thrusters make the car's 'flying' possible?

- (A) Two
- (B) Four
- (C) Six
- (D) Three

3. What powers the thrusters, according to Tesla?

- (A) Compressed gas stored in the car
- (B) Solar panels
- (C) Jet fuel
- (D) Gasoline

4. How fast did Tesla executives say the car could reach 60 miles per hour?

- (A) In five seconds
- (B) In three seconds
- (C) In one second
- (D) In ten seconds

5. When does Tesla say it will start making the Roadster 2?

- (A) 2030
- (B) 2020
- (C) 2026
- (D) 2028

6. What did Wired report about electric car sales in the United States?

- (A) They doubled
- (B) They stopped completely
- (C) They have stalled
- (D) They are booming

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: A 4: C 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Elon Musk, Tesla CEO: Said the car is not necessarily safety-optimized and that its thrusters will also help it take corners quickly.

2. Lars Moravy, Tesla vehicle engineering head: Said four thrusters enable the flying and that the final version would hopefully reach up to 230 miles per hour.

3. Wired: Noted the car is likely to draw attention from safety regulators and that many Tesla products have missed planned release dates.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):